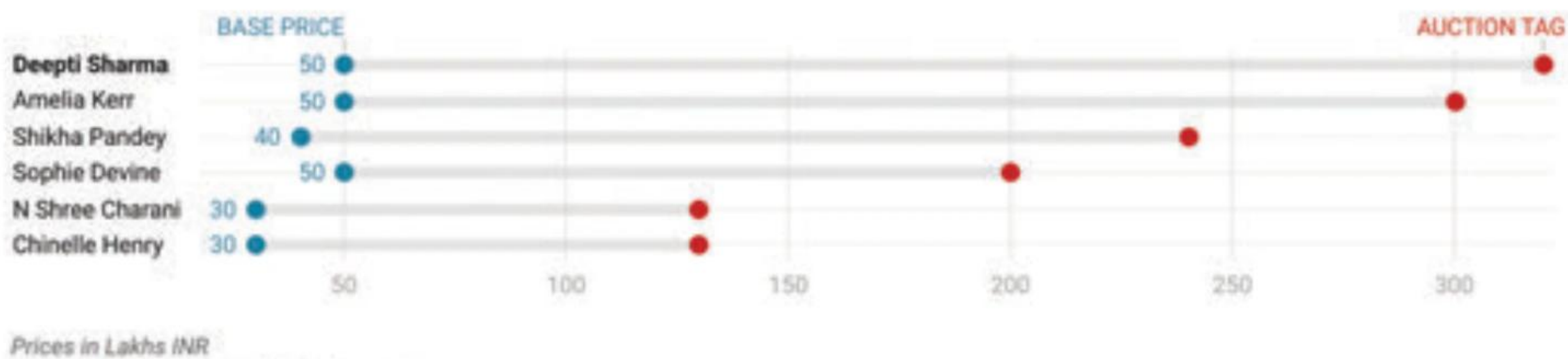


The biggest hikes in the WPL 2026 Auction

Track the biggest price jumps at the WPL 2026 Auction as top players saw massive bidding hikes across all five franchises in New Delhi.



and the utility of the established pool available. One wonders whether Healy's recent injury frequency went against her in the auction, particularly since the four overseas slots require efficacy and full fitness to pay maximum dividends.

That may also explain why someone like Lizelle Lee, a South African keeper-batter who now permanently resides in Australia, found favour. She has registered remarkable returns in the WBBL and 50-over domestic competitions Down Under, and her naturally explosive style prompted Delhi Capitals to potentially reunite her at the top of the order with her former opening partner Wolvaardt.

Another player who went shockingly unsold was Alana King, whose imperious run in the World Cup (remember that seven-wicket haul against South Africa?) more than validated her credentials. While restricted overseas slots play a role, it is astounding that no franchise saw value in her leg-spin and mean hitting ability late in an innings.

Balancing pragmatism with faith

The flip side is the responsibility franchises have to not use and discard players due to myopic visions for their setups. RCB's faith in Shreyanka Patil, shown when it retained her for ₹60 lakh, reduced her to tears.

Similarly, Pratika Rawal, who fractured her ankle during India's World Cup campaign, managed to secure the faith of the Warriorz regardless of whether she will be

cleared to play in the upcoming season, which is just a few weeks away. "We all know she's a superstar, we all know that," Nayar said about India's promising ODI opener. "Even though she's injured today, in the future she's going to be a star. One of the thought processes for me was to have a lot of Indian players who are superstars and can take this franchise forward and be the face of the franchise."

Delhi Capitals did something similar by retaining three Indian players — Jemimah Rodrigues, Shafali Verma, and Niki Prasad. Despite acquiring Wolvaardt, who also carries leadership pedigree, co-owner Parth Jindal was quick to underline that DC will have an Indian captain. Niki's retention is also a strong statement of belief. The U-19 World Cup-winning captain is a steady batter with ice in her veins in pressure situations. A talent to watch out for in the future, the Capitals have ensured that she blossoms under their wings. Left-arm spinner Sree Charani, who impressed in the World Cup, was blooded into the senior side after showing refreshing aggression and a knack for taking wickets in just two games for DC. The franchise sealed her services with a hefty ₹1.30 crore tag.

The auction was also a moment of recognition for many players toiling hard in the domestic circuit. Bharti Fulmali, a prolific accelerator for Vidarbha, is heading back to the Giants for ₹70 lakh after growing in that setup for the past few seasons. Maharashtra's Gautami Naik and

The crore club



Deepti Sharma

₹3.20 crore (UP Warriorz)

Amelia Kerr

₹3.00 crore (Mumbai Indians)

Shikha Pandey

₹2.40 crore (UP Warriorz)

Sophie Devine

₹2.00 crore (Gujarat Giants)

Meg Lanning

₹1.90 crore (UP Warriorz)

Chinelle Henry

₹1.30 crore (Delhi Capitals)

Shree Charani

₹1.30 crore (Delhi Capitals)

Phoebe Litchfield

₹1.20 crore (UP Warriorz)

Laura Wolvaardt

₹1.10 crore (Delhi Capitals)

Asha Sobhana

₹1.10 crore (UP Warriorz)

Georgia Wareham

₹1.00 crore (Gujarat Giants)

₹3.4 crore

The costliest signing in WPL history:

Smriti Mandhana for Royal Challengers Bengaluru in 2023